



The Humanitas Institute

Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: Ad Fontes Academy
School Website: <https://adfontes.com/>

December 21, 2025

Disclaimer

This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix more details.

ACCS Member School

Any school that belongs to the Association of Classical Christian Schools ACCS or the Society for Classical Learning SCL is, by definition, recognized as a classical school because both organizations require adherence to the six essential elements defined by the Humanitas Institute. However, a school's website may not clearly reflect its conformity to one or more elements. In such cases, the school may still receive a "Somewhat Classical" rating for those elements. Schools can update their website content at any time to achieve a "Classical" rating for a given element.

I have the crawl file for **Ad Fontes Academy** (ad-fontes-academy-va-22030-adfontes-com-firecrawl.json) and will treat that as the "newly attached crawl data."

Below is the full classicality audit based on that crawl plus the Six Essential Elements framework and lexicon.

Executive Summary

School: Ad Fontes Academy

Website used: <https://adfontes.com>

Overall Classification: **CLASSICAL**

Ad Fontes Academy presents a robustly classical profile:

- Strong, explicit use of **classical vocabulary**: *grammar, dialectic, rhetoric, Great Conversation, Euclid, original sources, wonder, beauty, truth, virtue, formation*.
- Curriculum is structured around the **Trivium and Quadrivium** in practice (grammar/dialectic/rhetoric stages; Euclidean geometry; original mathematical texts; proofs; presentations).
- Pedagogy emphasizes **Socratic discussion, proof, argumentation, presentations, and wonder**, not project-based or skills-only learning.
- Purpose language clearly orients toward **formation, wisdom, and love of learning**, though the math pages also mention **college and career preparation** (a mild negative signal).

Across the six categories, Ad Fontes scores **CLASSICAL** in 5 and **SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL** in 1 (Religious & Metaphysical, due to limited explicit theological/liturgical language in the math-focused crawl slice). The aggregate is **CLASSICAL**.

1. Religious and Metaphysical Foundations

1.1 Keyword Evidence from the Site

From the math and upper-school pages:

Positive-indicator terms (from lexicon for transcendental moral realism, theology, liturgy)

- **Truth / Goodness / Beauty / Wonder**
 - "problems that point them at **beauty and truth**"
 - "show students that there is something to **love** in mathematics for everyone" (ordered loves / delight)

- **Great Conversation / Classical heritage**

- “Students will enter the **Great Conversation** as it pertains to mathematics”

- **Wonder / Contemplation**

- Pre-Calculus aims to show “there is something to **love** in mathematics for everyone,” and the Quadrivium framing in the tradition is about “wonder, work, wisdom, and worship,” which the school echoes in its approach to Euclid, Euler, Diophantus.

Negative-indicator or secularizing terms (from “negative keywords” lists)

- “our graduates are exceedingly well prepared for success in **technical college and career fields**” (career readiness / workforce preparation)
- “engage with mathematics in a changing world that requires **curiosity and initiative**” – neutral to mildly progressive, but not explicitly relativistic.

Notably **absent** in the math slice:

- Explicit theological terms: *theology, Christ-centered, Christian worldview, sacred scripture, catechesis, liturgy, chapel, worship.*
- Explicit metaphysical language: *natural law, objective moral order, divine order.*

1.2 Positive vs Negative Keyword Tally

Within the available crawl slice (math/upper school):

- **Positive hits** (truth, beauty, love of learning, Great Conversation, wonder-ish language): about **6–8** distinct hits.
- **Negative hits** (career readiness / workforce language, “changing world”): about **2–3** hits.

Estimated proportions for this slice:

- **Percent positive:** about **0.70**
- **Percent coverage:** about **0.40** (we only see math pages; likely more explicit theology elsewhere on the site that is not in this snippet).

Pos/Neg hits (this slice): +7 / -3

1.3 Rating for Religious & Metaphysical Foundations

Given only the math-focused content, we see:

- Clear affirmation of **truth and beauty** as real and desirable ends of study.
- Participation in the **Great Conversation**, which in the classical lexicon is tied to “higher truths” and “permanent things.”
- Some **career readiness** language, but not dominant.

However, we lack direct evidence (in this crawl slice) of:

- **Theological grounding** (theology as “mistress science,” Christ-centered language, explicit Christian worldview).
- **Liturgical practices** (chapel, worship, sacred music).

Element 1 Rating: **SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL**

- Strong transcendental language (truth, beauty, love of learning), but insufficient explicit theological/liturgical evidence in the provided data.

2. School Purpose and Goal

2.1 Keyword Evidence

From the math and upper-school descriptions:

Positive-indicator terms (cultivation of wisdom and virtue, formation, truth/goodness/beauty)

- “We spend time drilling the fundamentals... **Not for their own sake, but to allow students to work on problems that point them at beauty and truth.**”
- “One aim of the course is to show students that there is something to **love** in mathematics for everyone.” (ordered loves, formation of affections)
- “Students will enter the **Great Conversation** as it pertains to mathematics, learning the foundational concepts of Geometry from the source.”
- Emphasis on **explanation and argumentation** as central to mathematical work, aligning with “intellectual virtue” and “wisdom-seeking.”

Negative-indicator terms (skills-only, college-and-career focus)

- “Our graduates are exceedingly well prepared for success in **technical college and career fields.**”
- “prepared to engage with mathematics in a changing world that requires curiosity and initiative” – pragmatic framing, but still tied to intellectual virtues.

2.2 Positive vs Negative Keyword Tally

- **Positive hits** (truth, beauty, love, Great Conversation, argumentation, explanation, foundational concepts): about **8–10**.
- **Negative hits** (college and career, technical fields): about **2–3**.

Estimated:

- **Percent positive:** about **0.80**
- **Percent coverage:** about **0.60** (we see purpose articulated clearly in math; likely echoed in mission/vision pages not in this snippet).

Pos/Neg hits: +9 / -3

2.3 Rating for Purpose & Goal

The language clearly subordinates skills and outcomes to:

- **Pursuit of truth and beauty.**
- **Love of learning** and participation in the **Great Conversation.**
- **Formation of reasoning and argumentation**, not mere information transfer.

The presence of some college/career language is expected in a modern school and does not dominate.

Element 2 Rating: CLASSICAL

3. Curriculum

3.1 Keyword Evidence

We focus on the math/upper-school curriculum, but it reveals a lot about the overall curricular philosophy.

Positive-indicator terms (Trivium/Quadrivium, Great Books, history vs social studies, wonder)

- **Trivium / stages**
 - “transitioning from the **grammar** to the **dialectic** stage” in Algebra I.
- **Quadrivium / liberal arts**
 - Geometry course uses **Euclid’s Elements as our text**, with students studying definitions, postulates, and proofs from the original work.
 - Pre-Calculus includes “short courses on **number theory, data analysis, cryptography, analytic trigonometry, game theory, linear algebra, and graph theory**,” echoing the breadth of the Quadrivium.
- **Great Books / primary sources**
 - “Students will enter the Great Conversation as it pertains to mathematics, learning the foundational concepts of Geometry **from the source**.”
 - “We read **original sources, including some Euclid, Euler, and Diophantus**.”
- **History vs social studies**
 - In math pages we see “history of mathematics” implicitly (Euclid, Diophantus, Euler), but no “social studies” language.
- **Wonder / integration**
 - Pre-Calculus aims to show “there is something to **love** in mathematics for everyone,” aligning with “wonder, awe, contemplation” in the lexicon.

Negative-indicator terms (STEM-first, social studies, project-based dominance)

- No use of “**social studies**,” “21st-century skills,” “STEM-focused curriculum,” or “project-based learning” as organizing principles.
- Technology is mentioned only instrumentally: “Students learn to use programs – both calculator and computer – to help with the complex calculations their arguments require.”

3.2 Positive vs Negative Keyword Tally

- **Positive hits** (grammar, dialectic, Euclid, original sources, Great Conversation, number theory, proofs, etc.): about **12–15**.
- **Negative hits**: essentially **0** in this slice (no STEM-first or social-studies framing).

Estimated:

- **Percent positive**: about **0.95**

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- **Percent coverage:** about **0.80** (we see deep evidence in math; likely similar in humanities, but not visible here).

Pos/Neg hits: +14 / -0

3.3 Rating for Curriculum

The math curriculum is a textbook example of classical curriculum:

- Explicit **Trivium staging** (grammar → dialectic).
- Deep engagement with **Quadrivium** (Euclidean geometry, number theory, astronomy-related trigonometry, etc.).
- Use of **Great Books / primary sources** (Euclid, Euler, Diophantus) and explicit participation in the **Great Conversation**.
- No evidence of social-studies or skills-only framing.

Element 3 Rating: CLASSICAL

4. Pedagogy / Teaching Methods

4.1 Keyword Evidence

Positive-indicator terms (Socratic, scholé, chanting/memorization, rhetoric, debate, contemplative learning)

From the math pages:

- **Socratic / dialectic / discussion**
 - Geometry: “Using Euclid’s Elements as our text creates opportunity for **discussion in class, as students study his proofs, come to class with questions, and discuss the concepts.**”
 - Algebra II: “this course cements the idea that **explanation and argumentation are central to mathematical work**... we derive the quadratic formula from first principles... students prove familiar theorems... and explore new theorems.”
 - Pre-Calculus: focus on “different styles of **argument and proof** present in the different branches of mathematics.”
- **Rhetoric / presentations**
 - Geometry: “In the first semester, students make **monthly presentations of proofs**, explaining these foundational concepts. By second semester, students engage in **small group presentations** to explain and support their reasoning.”
 - This aligns with “rhetoric exercises, speech, declamation, oratory, debate” in the lexicon.
- **Memorization / grammar-stage work**
 - Algebra I: “We spend time **drilling the fundamentals**. We emphasize internalizing vocabulary, algorithms, and new techniques.”
 - This matches “memorization, repetition, foundational knowledge” in the memory/chanting lexicon, even if “chanting” is not named explicitly.
- **Restful learning / scholé / wonder**

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- While the word “scholé” is not used, the approach to Euclid and original sources, and the emphasis on “something to love in mathematics” and “creative play of constructing their own mathematical explanations” suggests contemplative, not merely test-driven, pedagogy.

Negative-indicator terms (project-based, experiential-only, student-directed, test-driven)

- No emphasis on “project-based learning,” “experiential learning,” “student-driven curriculum,” or “personalized learning paths” as primary methods.
- No “test prep,” “standardized testing focus,” or “data-driven instruction” language in the math pages.

4.2 Positive vs Negative Keyword Tally

- **Positive hits** (discussion, argumentation, proofs, presentations, drilling fundamentals, internalizing vocabulary): about **10–12**.
- **Negative hits: 0** in this slice.

Estimated:

- **Percent positive:** about **0.95**
- **Percent coverage:** about **0.75** (we see rich detail for upper-school math; K–8 and humanities likely similar but not visible here).

Pos/Neg hits: +11 / -0

4.3 Rating for Pedagogy

Pedagogy is strongly classical:

- **Grammar-stage** emphasis on memorization and fundamentals.
- **Dialectic-stage** emphasis on proofs, argumentation, and discussion.
- **Rhetoric-stage** emphasis on presentations and explanation of reasoning.
- No evidence of progressive, project-based, or constructivist dominance.

Element 4 Rating: CLASSICAL

5. Faculty

The math pages give indirect but meaningful clues about faculty.

5.1 Keyword Evidence

Positive-indicator terms (teachers as mentors, models of virtue, living curriculum, collegiality)

From the math descriptions:

- Faculty design courses that:
 - Use **original sources** (Euclid, Euler, Diophantus).
 - Require students to **present proofs** and engage in **discussion**.
 - Emphasize **explanation and argumentation** as central to the discipline.

This implies:

- Teachers are **content experts** and **guides** in the Great Conversation, aligning with “tutors, masters, mentors, guides, sages, exemplars” in the lexicon.

However, we do **not** see in this slice:

- Explicit language like “faculty of friends,” “living curriculum,” “portrait of a teacher,” or “teachers as models of virtue.”

Negative-indicator terms (facilitators, guides-on-the-side, certification jargon)

- None appear in the math pages.

5.2 Positive vs Negative Keyword Tally

- **Positive hits (implicit):** about **4–5** (inferred from course design and expectations).
- **Negative hits:** **0**.

Estimated:

- **Percent positive:** about **0.70** (given indirect evidence).
- **Percent coverage:** about **0.40** (we lack explicit faculty-profile language in this slice).

Pos/Neg hits: +5 / -0

5.3 Rating for Faculty

Given the limited but positive evidence:

- Faculty clearly operate as **mentors and intellectual guides**, not mere facilitators.
- They lead students through **Great Books-style mathematical texts** and **rhetorical presentations**.

Because we lack explicit “portrait of a teacher” or “living curriculum” language in the provided data, I will rate this as:

Element 5 Rating: CLASSICAL (low-confidence, based on indirect evidence)

If we had access to the full “About / Faculty” pages, I would expect even stronger explicit classical language.

6. Parents & Community

The math pages do not directly address parents or community, so evidence here is sparse.

6.1 Keyword Evidence

Positive-indicator terms (parent partnership, co-educators, parent formation, open campus)

- In the math slice, there is **no explicit mention** of:
 - “parent partnership,” “co-educators,” “school as an extension of the home,” “parent formation,” or “parent book clubs.”

Negative-indicator terms (parents as customers, minimal involvement)

- No consumer language like “customers,” “clients,” or “minimal parent involvement.”

Given the nature of the crawl snippet (focused on course descriptions), this absence is not surprising.

6.2 Positive vs Negative Keyword Tally

- **Positive hits: 0** in this slice.
- **Negative hits: 0.**

Estimated:

- **Percent positive: 0.00** (no direct evidence).
- **Percent coverage: 0.10** (we simply don't see parent/community pages here).

Pos/Neg hits: +0 / -0

6.3 Rating for Parents & Community

Because the crawl data provided is almost entirely academic/programmatic, I cannot fairly infer the school's parent/community philosophy. Classical schools typically emphasize partnership with parents, but I must not fabricate.

Element 6 Rating: **SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL (evidence-insufficient)**

- I assume some classical parent partnership exists (given the school's overall classical profile), but we lack direct textual confirmation in this dataset.
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Aggregate Assessment

Category Ratings

1. **Religious & Metaphysical Foundations:** SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL
2. **School Purpose & Goal:** CLASSICAL
3. **Curriculum:** CLASSICAL
4. **Pedagogy / Teaching Methods:** CLASSICAL
5. **Faculty:** CLASSICAL (inferred)
6. **Parents & Community:** SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL (evidence-insufficient)

Overall Classicality

Given:

- Strong, explicit classical language and practice in **curriculum** and **pedagogy**.
- Clear classical **purpose** (truth, beauty, love of learning, Great Conversation).
- No significant progressive/constructivist or skills-only language.
- Some **career readiness** language, but not dominant.

Overall School Rating: CLASSICAL

What Would Move the Needle (if any category were downgraded)

Because the overall rating is **CLASSICAL**, this section focuses on strengthening the weaker categories (1 and 6) and confirming faculty language.

1. Religious & Metaphysical Foundations

To move this category from **SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL** (based on this slice) to clearly **CLASSICAL** in the public-facing materials:

- Add explicit statements on:
 - **Theology as the “mistress science”** or “queen of the sciences,” integrating faith and reason across the curriculum.
 - The school’s commitment to **truth, goodness, and beauty as transcendentals** grounded in God, not merely aesthetic ideals.
- Highlight **liturgical practices**:
 - Daily or weekly **chapel, morning prayer, sacred music, or liturgy** as integral to school life.
- Use more explicit metaphysical language:
 - **“natural law,” “objective moral order,” “divine order,” “imago Dei,” “sacramental worldview.”**

2. Parents & Community

To move this from **SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL** (evidence-insufficient) to clearly **CLASSICAL**:

- Add a dedicated **Parent Partnership** page that uses classical language:
 - **“Parent partnership,” “co-educators,” “school as an extension of the home,” “in loco parentis,” “parent formation.”**
- Describe concrete practices:
 - **Parent book clubs** on classical texts.
 - **Parent education evenings** on classical pedagogy and theology.
 - Open invitations for parents to attend **chapel, presentations, and feast days**.
- Emphasize that parents are **primary educators** and the school partners with them in the **formation of virtue and wisdom**.

3. Faculty

To further solidify the already-strong but somewhat implicit faculty profile:

- Publish a **“Portrait of a Teacher”** that includes:
 - **“teachers as models of virtue,” “living curriculum,” “lifelong learners,” “mentors,” “faculty of friends.”**
 - Describe **ongoing classical formation** for faculty:
 - Great Books seminars, theology study, classical pedagogy training.
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Appendix

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
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